Fin and Euba

By Audrey Cefaly

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: Fin and Euba are friends and co-workers at a paper mill in Cantonment, Florida.
ACTRESS 2: They also share space in a rooming house, which they are desperately trying to escape, due to the tyrannical landlady who has a penchant for strict rules and tacky yard art.
ACTRESS 1: Unbeknownst to Euba, Fin submits some of Euba's amateur photos to Life Magazine.
ACTRESS 2: Euba receives a reply from Life, but is reluctant to open it for fear or rejection, or worse…acceptance.
ACTRESS 1: Fin and Euba sit on the porch contemplating their lives and their plans for escape.
TOGETHER: Fin and Euba by Audrey Cefaly

note to actors

Fin and Euba are poor and scrappy. They say and do things that may seem surreal or comical, but in all things there is a truth to their ways ... they are not caricatures. That is to say ... they are very real people with real problems. Every effort should be made to make them as human and as genuine as possible, to identify their core beliefs and to portray them honestly . . .

FIN: Hey.

EUBA: Hey. *[They stare out at the highway. An occasional car speeds by.]*

FIN: It's gettin' cold.

EUBA: Yeah, it's gettin' cold. *[Silence.]*

FIN: Bernice told me you got a letter in mail-call today.

EUBA: *[Somewhat annoyed.]* Yeah.

FIN: From *Life* magazine?

EUBA: Bernice talks too much.

FIN: Well, ain't you gonna tell me what it says? You been waitin' for that letter since June.

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EUBA: No.

FIN: No?

EUBA: I ain't read it.

FIN: Why not?

EUBA: Personal reasons.

FIN: Oooh. Oh, I see. OK Alright. That's fine ... you don't want to tell me.

EUBA: Good.

FIN: Your best friend.

EUBA: Yup.

FIN: The only person you could trust in the whole wide world.

EUBA: Yup.

FIN: But if you don't want to tell me

EUBA: Nope *[Silence.]*

FIN: *[Annoyed.]* I shoulda' worn my jacket.

EUBA: Mnnn hmn.

FIN: Two weeks til' Thanksgiving ... can you believe that?

EUBA: Double shifts again all next week.

FIN: You're kiddin'?!

EUBA: Fat Charlie told Thelma-'n' Thelma told me.

FIN: Good! I need the money.

EUBA: I need sleep more than I need the money.

FIN: That's the truth. *[Pause.]* I heard something, but you ain't gon' like it.

EUBA: What?

FIN: Miss Vera's fixin' to raise the rent next month.

EUBA: Where'd you hear that?!

FIN: Bernice. Said she overheard her *talkin'* about it on the phone to Brother Herbert.

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EUBA: How much?

FIN: I don't know. *[Pause.]*

EUBA: *[Bravery.]* You know I'd move in a heartbeat.

FIN: Me too.

EUBA: Too many rules.

FIN: I know it! Let's do it.

EUBA: What?

FIN: Move.

EUBA: You're crazy.

FIN: I'm serious!

EUBA: It's too far, Fin. The next rooming house is two miles down ... that's way too far to walk to work.

FIN: Lou Anne lives down there at Scooter's. We could ride in with her. And he don't have no rules, neither, except cash only.

EUBA: Cash only?

FIN: Cash only. And no pets.

EUBA: What about a fish? *[Pause.]* Could I have fish?

FIN: I bet you could have a fish. What like a goldfish?

EUBA: No ..one of them pretty ones ... with the pretty colors.

FIN: Oh yeah! I like them. Fish are good. *[Pause.]* What do you think?

EUBA: I don't know.

FIN: Let's just think on it.

EUBA: OK

FIN: We'll just think on it. That's what we'll do.

EUBA: *[Trying to close the subject.1* OK Let's *think* on it.

FIN: *[Overlapping.]* OK *[Pause.]* I'm thinkin'. *[They both sit quietly for a moment trying to work through the details.]*

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FIN: You alright?

EUBA: Yup.

FIN: They got a new foreman comin' in next week.

EUBA: Where's Lila?

FIN: Fat Charlie sent her home. She couldn't keep up.

EUBA: *[Amused.]* When's the baby due?

FIN: Any day.

EUBA: How's she look?

FIN: She looks good. She looks real good. Big.

EUBA: I miss havin' her on my shift.

EUBA: She'll be back.

FIN: Nuh uh! She's movin'.

EUBA: What?

FIN: Well, you remember how her husband went through basic training last summer?

EUBA: Yeah.

FIN: They just assigned him to a unit at Ft. Bragg and they're movin' soon as the baby's born.

EUBA: What?

FIN: She's mad as a hornet too. She just got the baby's room all fixed up and everything. *[The front porch light flashes.] [To Euba.]* 15 minutes. *[Calling.]* Yes, *ma 'am!*

EUBA: God, I can't stand that woman!

FIN: *[Overlapping.]* She gives me the creeps! Her and them 13 *cats.*

EUBA: *Seventeen.* Ginger had her litter this mornin'.

FIN: *[A warning.]* That's it! We're movin' to Scooters. *[Pause.]* I mean it, Euba! I'm callin' Scooter tomorrow. *[Pause.]* Euba?

EUBA: Yeah?

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FIN: When you gon' open that letter?

EUBA: *[Grimacing.] Life* magazine does not care about any of the stupid pictures I took in high school, Fin. Get real.

FIN: I didn't send 'em those, Miss *smartie pants.* I sent 'em the ones you took at the plant during the strike last year.

EUBA: [EUBA *has a moment of hope, but quickly dismisses it.]* Whatever.

FIN: What if it's a job offer?

EUBA: Oh, get serious, Fin. You think you can just send my pictures to some big shot at *Life* magazine and expect a job offer?

FIN: *[Overlapping.]* Oh, give me a little more credit, will ya? I did not just send them to any old *big shot. [Proudly.]* I sent them to the *Executive Editor,* if you must know. I took his name right off the inside cover.

EUBA: *[Sarcastically.]* Now, that makes all the difference, don't it?

FIN: *[Staring at* EUBA *blankly.]* You are so negative. *Negative. Negative. Negative.*

EUBA: *[Overlapping.] Realistic.*

FIN: Yes. That too! And negative. *[Pause.]* I bet it's a job offer! What do ya think?

EUBA: I don't know and I don't care.

FIN: Don't lie.

EUBA: I ain't lyin.' I don't want to know.

FIN: Why?

EUBA: It's better not knowing.

FIN: Better?

EUBA: I didn't send the pictures, Fin! You did!

FIN: It's what you wanted.

EUBA: No, Fin. It's what *you* wanted.

FIN: You said. You *dreamed* about it.

EUBA: No I didn't.

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FIN: Don't lie! Euba. You have been dreamin' about taking pictures for *Life* magazine ever since high school.

EUBA: OK, yeah, alright. Yeah, I dreamed about it, but that don't mean I *want* it. *[Pause.]*

FIN: *[Annoyed.]* That don't make no sense, Euba. Dreamin' ... wantin' ... same thing.

EUBA: No, it ain't. Dreamin' is dreamin,' that's all it is. Wantin' means you're willin' to work for it and I ain't and that's *all.*

FIN: What are you *talking* about?

EUBA: Do I dream about it? Yes! Of course, I do. When I'm out there on that line all day and my feet are so swole up I can't think straight? I dream about it. Or when Bugger James comes into *my* room stead of his own at 4 a.m. cuz he's so *blind* from drunk. I dream about it. Or how bout, every mornin' scrambling for a warm shower 'stead of ice cold, cuz I slept in two minutes late. Fin, I dream about getting out every minute of every day of my life.

FIN: Well, what are you waitin' for? *[Holding up the letter.]* This is your *chance,* Euba.

EUBA: *[Taking the letter.]* Because. If I open this letter. And it says what I know it's gonna say ...

FIN: What?

EUBA: ... then I have nothin'.

FIN: But what if they *want you!?*

EUBA: What if they don't?

FIN: What if they do?

EUBA: What if they don't?! What if I open that letter, and it tells me I'm no better than anybody else in this-

FIN: Oh, come on!!! If! had *half* your talent, I'd march right down to that office and I'd tell *thatJat-bastard* Charlie to kiss my ass. I'd *quit.* With no notice! And I'd start walking til' I hit Atlanta. And you wanna know what else?!?! I WOULDN'T LOOK BACK!!! I'D NEVER LOOK BACK! Not even for you, baby. Not even for you.

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EUBA: Well, thanks a lot.

FIN: It's nothing personal.

EUBA: I know it.

FIN: Open the letter!

EUBA: Stop it!

FIN: Euba!

EUBA: Leave it alone, Fin.

FIN: It's a *sin* what you're doin.' Throwin' away your God-given talent.

EUBA: How come you can't just drop it?!

FIN: No, I won't. And you wanna know why?

EUBA: 'Cause you ain't got any dreams of your own, that's why! *[Pause.]*

FIN: *[Stung.] Nice.* Turn it back on me why don't you?

EUBA: *[Overlapping.]* I didn't mean it, I'm sorry.

FIN: *[Overlapping.]* Oh, save it, Euba! I know what I want. And you can call it dreamin', wantin' WHATEVER. Kids? Yep. On the list. One girl. One boy. And a husband some day, if! can find one who'll have me. Somebody to *love.* Somebody who will love me back. A white house, with a little wrap around porch ... on a little quiet street-

EUBA: *[Overlapping.]* Don't forget the white picket fence.

FIN: *[Continuing defiantly.]* in a little quiet city-that don't smell like ... something *dead.* And just maybe, when I'm old and ugly, I want a bloodhound named Jake ... who knows his name, who will come when I call him and who will love me, no matter what, cuz that's what dogs do.

EUBA: *[Softening up now.]* Sounds like you got it all planned out.

FIN: *[Sincerely.]* Yeah, well, I ain't special like you, Euba.

EUBA: Oh, come on-

FIN: No, no, it don't bother me. You bother me. You say you want a fish, but you

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don't even know what kind!

EUBA: Fish? Fish? We're talking about fish now? I know what kind of *fish,* Fin, I just can't think of the *name,* that's all.

FIN: My point exactly.

EUBA: I know what I want.

FIN: No, you don't.

EUBA: Yes, I-

FIN: No! No you don't, Euba. You sit here and [complain] and you moan about this place ... about *gettin' out.* But it's all just words, idn't it? You never do anything. You never do anything about it.

EUBA: I'm happy right where I am, thank you very much.

FIN: *[Aghast.]* Don't say that! Don't you ever say that!

EUBA: Leave it alone, Fin.

FIN: *As long as you can live with it. [Pause.]* Come Sunday morning and you're sittin' there, *7th row center* at Southside Baptist. Trying to explain to the Good Lord why you took the *gifts-the gifts-he* gave you and THREW THEM ALL AWAY! You hear me?!?! Just threw 'em away. Now what do you think he would have to say about that?

EUBA: I can't speak for Jesus, Fin.

FIN: Well, I can. *[Pause.]* And I'll tell you what he'd say. Shame. On. You! Shaammme on you, Yolanda Eubanks! [EUBA *quickly pulls out the letter and starts ripping it up.]* Stop it! What are you doing?!?! Are you insane?!?! Euba!! [EUBA *holds a lighter up to the letter in warning. A cold menacing demeanor washes over her.]*

FIN: You wouldn't! [EUBA *flicks the lighter "on. '1*

EUBA: You wanna take that chance?

FIN: Don't do it. You'll never live it down, Euba.

EUBA: *[Overlapping.]* You better *get back,* Fin! Now, I need you to leave me be on this, you

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hear me?!?!

FIN: Euba, please!

EUBA: BACK AWAY! I'll torch it!

FIN: I believe you would. I do. I'm backing away ... see me ... I'm back. Now put the lighter down.

EUBA: *[Pointedly.]* Now, this is *my life.* My life. And it's mine for me to decide if I want to throw it away, you got it?

FIN: Yes!

EUBA: No more TALK! No more nothin'!!

FIN: *[Overlapping.]* OK Yes. Yes. OK I'm sorry. Please ... just ... just ... just ... put the lighter down. *[Overlapping.* EUBA *accidentally burns herself on the lighter. She drops the lighter and the papers on the ground.]*

EUBA: Ow! *[Silence.] [A realization.]* I'm crazy. I am. I'm crazy. That's the only explanation.

FIN: No. No.

EUBA: I mean it, Fin. Whatever this is ... It ain't normal. It ain't- something's wrong with me.

FIN: Euba?

EUBA: *[Overlapping.]* I'm scared, Fin. You hear me? I'm scared!

FIN: Of what? A letter?

EUBA: No! Of ... of everything. Afraid to go. Afraid to stay. Livin'. Dyin'. Stuck in this house with that crazy witch. No car. No phone. With no nothin', Fin, when you think about it. We work in a mill that spits poison twenty-four seven .... And the smell, God, that smell ... it turns my stomach, Fin. I can't get away from it. It's in my clothes, it's in my hair, it's in my sheets! Fin! It's in my sheets! I've probably got some sort of deadly disease ... eatin' away at me on the inside .... For Christ's sake, Fin, we have to wait for a northern wind to barbecue! God, I hate it here! I hate this place.

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FIN: Then leave!

EUBA: *[Quietry.]* What if the next place is no better? Ya ever thinka that?

FIN: Wha-

EUBA: What if the next place ... is *worse* ... than this?

FIN: [FIN *takes in her surroundings.i* That's a scary thought, Euba.

EUBA: You make it all sound so easy. Just pick up .... Go somewhere ... do something ... I know there's better places, Fin. Don't think I don't know that. But, Fin ... I can't. I can't ... *move.* I can't I'm-I'm stuck.

FIN: You are NOT stuck. You listen to me. You are NOT stuck. Ain't none of us stuck.

EUBA: Yeah, I am. Oh, God, I can't breathe!

FIN: Shh shh ... OK, OK, caaallmmm down. Calm down. Take a deep breath. Take another one. Sit down here for a second and catch your breath. Whooo whooaa OK, now keeeep breathing .... Don't forget to breathe. Everything's gon' be back to normal here ... now just keep breathing. You OK? [EUBA *nods yes. They sit in silence for a minute.* FIN *pats* EUBA's *back and pushes the hair back from her eyes.]* It's tough. I know. But ... it might help if you remember ... God never gives us more than we can handle. [E UBA *slowly turns and stares blankly at* FIN] *[Backpedaling.]* Well, sometimes. Sometimes he does. Sometimes, it is just a *little* bit more than we can handle. *[Pause.]* But that's why we have each other. [EUBA *gathers the pieces of the letter and stands for a moment looking down at them. She is resolved now. She lights the papers.*

FIN:. [FIN *puts the blanket around her and sits. The lull of the crickets and heaviness of the air envelope them both. They resume once again to staring out at the lonely highway.]* It's getting' cold out here.

EUBA: Yeah.

FIN: Don't you think it's gettin' cold?

EUBA: Yeah. *[Pause.]* Yeah, it's gettin' cold.

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